troops who were assigned to the multinational force. At this time, Bill Clark, who'd been my national security advisor for almost two years, asked to be relieved of his post, and agreed to take on the slower-paced job of secretary of the interior; he was fatigued and wanted a change.

When Jim Baker heard about it, he told me he was getting a little tired of the routine as White House chief of staff and asked me to give him the NSC job. He proposed that Mike Deaver, whom I knew well from our California days, take over his job.

I agreed to this. But then Ed Meese, Bill Clark, Bill Casey, and Cap Weinberger got together and tried to convince me it was a bad idea. Some were not enthusiastic about having Mike, whose job involved overseeing White House political and public relations, become chief of staff. There was also resistance to Jim as national security advisor. I decided to reverse myself and scrap the change. Otherwise, I thought, the result would be friction among the cabinet and the White House staff.

"Jim took it well but Mike was pretty upset," I noted in my diary. "It was an unhappy day all around. An NSPG [National Security Planning Group] meeting on Lebanon. No decisions, just a listing of the problems. Not a pleasant evening what with all the hassle over the N.S.C. spot."

After that, Bill Casey and some of my more conservative supporters began pushing me to give the NSC job to Jeane Kirkpatrick, who was either tired or bored after more than two years at the UN. She had her heart set on the job and told me so. I admired Jeane, but I had noticed there was some bad chemistry between her and George Shultz, so I decided to give the spot to Bud McFarlane.

My decision not to appoint Jim Baker as national security advisor, I suppose, was a turning point for my administration, although I had no idea at the time how significant it would prove to be.